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STUDIES IN MACHIAVELLIANISM

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To Niccolò Machiavelli

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Studies in Machiavellianism

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CHAPTER I WHY MACHIAVELLI?

Richard Christie

Since the publication of *The Prince* in 1532, the name of its author has come to designate the use of guile, deceit, and opportunism in interpersonal relations. Traditionally, the "Machiavellian" is someone who views and manipulates others for his own purposes. But is it true that the person who agrees with Machiavelli's ideas behaves differently from the one who disagrees with him? This book describes efforts to answer this question.

Historians disagree as to whether Machiavelli was a cynic who wrote political satire, a patriot, or the first modern political scientist [see Jensen (1960) for a comparison of modern scholars' differences on this point]. The present concern is not with Machiavelli as an historic figure, but as the source of ideas about those who manipulate others.

The chapters that follow are based on empirical findings, and in them we will adhere to the currently approved canons of social psychological reporting. However, one of the complaints frequently made by students, and often by their professors as well, is that most research reports are presented in a highly stylized state of dessication. John Crowe Ransom (1927), in a different context, used a couplet which reminds me of much current scientific writing:

No belly and no bowels,
Only consonants and vowels.

When technical writing is well done, it conveys the relevant information concisely. Too often, though, it leaves one with the impression that the actual research proceeded as neatly and colorlessly as the report. The genesis of the hunch or chance observation that sets the research in motion, the false starts and brilliant insights that don't work, the unanticipated botches which can ruin a study, the excitement of scanning data to see if it bears out hypotheses, the painful reevaluation of material which runs counter to predictions, and the elation when all the pieces fall into place — all of these rarely appear in technical work. In this chapter, therefore, before renouncing personal prounouns and prejudices, I would like to describe informally the genesis and development of an idea: the Machiavellian orientation in interpersonal behavior.

During 1954–1955 I was a Fellow at the Center for Advanced Studies in the Behavioral Sciences. It was the first year of the Center's operation, and it was a

unique experience for the Fellows. Most of us had never had a year without any outside commitments, and we were enjoying it in idyllic surroundings with others who were equally overwhelmed by their good fortune. After the initial shock had worn off, a period of contagious anxiety began to develop. What could we possibly do to justify this opportunity? Few of us were particularly modest about our scholarly abilities, but the perceived necessity of producing a Great Work was awesome.

A consequence of this was the formation of work groups centered around topics of mutual interest. Cynics observed that the primary function of these groups seemed to be the mutual alleviation of anxiety, but that was not their sole function. Their major purpose was to bring together people from diverse disciplines for the exchange of ideas on a common subject. Many of us had come from university settings in which psychologists talked mostly with other psychologists, sociologists with sociologists, political scientists with political scientists. At the Center, commonness of interest rather than the formal discipline to which one belonged was paramount.

One group in which I participated was composed of social scientists who were interested in political behavior. We referred to ourselves as the "True Believer" work group [the title came from the book by Eric Hoffer (1951)], since we were interested in exploring the psychological and sociological factors underlying membership in political and religious extremist organizations.

My own interest in the topic had been piqued by collaboration (Christie & Jahoda, 1954) in a study of the methodology and findings of *The Authoritarian Personality* (Adorno, Frenkel-Brunswik, Levinson, & Sanford, 1950). The personality description of those scoring high in ethnic prejudice and professing right-wing political ideology rang intuitively true to me. These were familiar characteristics to one who had spent his early life in the Bible Belt. There was, however, one aspect of Shils' (1954) critique which also rang true. He pointed out that extremists of the political Right, with rare exception, were extremely ineffective in political movements. Their very extremity of ideology coupled with a concomitant inflexibility of political tactics did not permit them to make the compromises which are necessary for political success.

After the first few meetings of the "True Believer" work group, during which the literature was reveiwed, we broke up into smaller groups with more focused interests. Two political scientists, Robert Agger and Frank Pinner, and I became especially interested in the leaders of such extremist groups. A good part of the empirical work we had found dealt with the followers, the dupes, the faceless ones in the crowd. Although there was also a vast literature on the characteristics of formally designated leaders, very little work had been done on those who actually manipulated the followers, those few who were crucial to the decision-

making process. In taking this direction, we were guided by the reflections of Harold Lasswell (1954), who had just stressed the lack of psychological research on power relationships in his comments about *The Authoritarian Personality.*

Our readings confirmed the impression that much of the speculation about the personal characteristics of those wielding power over others was in terms of lay psychology or had been largely influenced by concepts taken from psychopathology. The social visibility of leaders tends to draw attention to them. Both their virtues and their flaws are more publicized and written about than those of less outstanding members of society. This makes it possible to develop a psychiatric interpretation of Napoleon's sexual behavior, while similar behavior by foot soldiers in his armies is more apt to elicit a sociological explanation. Although depth psychology has been more frequently invoked to explain the behavior of prominent figures than those of less renown, it does not necessarily follow that those who exert influence are more prone to psychopathology. We were reluctant to accept the premise implicit in much of the literature that pathology and power are intertwined in the manipulator.

Consequently, Agger, Pinner, and I adopted the strategy of viewing the manipulator or operator in terms of an hypothetical role model. We asked ourselves what abstract characteristics must someone who is effective in controlling others have? What kind of person should he be?

The following characteristics struck us as being important:

1. *A relative lack of affect in interpersonal relationships.* In general, it seemed that success in getting others to do what one wishes them to do would be enhanced by viewing them as objects to be manipulated rather than as individuals with whom one has empathy. The greater the emotional involvement with others, the greater is the likelihood of identifying with their point of view. Once empathy occurs, it becomes more difficult to use psychological leverage to influence others to do things they may not want to do.

2. *A lack of concern with conventional morality.* Conventional morality is difficult to define, but we were thinking here in terms of the findings that most people think lying, cheating, and other forms of deceit are, although common, reprehensible. Whether manipulators are amoral or immoral is a moot problem, and one which probably concerns them less than those who are manipulated. The premise here is that those who manipulate have an utilitarian rather than a moral view of their interactions with others.

3. *A lack of gross psychopathology.* The manipulator was hypothesized as taking an instrumentalist or rational view of others. Such a person would make errors in evaluating other individuals and the situation if his emotional needs seriously distorted his perceptions. Presumably, most neurotics and psychotics show deficiencies in reality testing and, by and large, fail in crucial ways in

relating to others. Note that we were not suggesting that manipulators are the epitome of mental health; we were proposing that their contact with at least the more objective aspects of reality would have to be, almost by definition, within the normal range.

4. *Low ideological commitment.* The essence of successful manipulation is a focus upon getting things done rather than a focus upon long-range ideological goals. Although manipulators might be found in organizations of diverse ideologies, they should be more involved in tactics for achieving possible ends than in an inflexible striving for an ultimate idealistic goal.

It is one thing to speculate that successful "operators" are lacking in interpersonal affect, low in concern with conventional morality, devoid of gross psychopathology, and have low ideological commitment. A more crucial question is whether such individuals do in fact exist, and, if so, where they flourish. The Center Fellows that year were a unique resource. Almost every Fellow was either a "star" in the behavioral sciences or the protégé of one.

We decided to take advantage of the presence of such a group of persons. Agger, Pinner, and I interviewed a number of junior fellows about their relations with, and their reactions to, the people who were responsible for their training and for their being at the Center. The interviews were not prestructured, but the questions were guided by the four points above, fitting the abstract model.

Perhaps we asked leading questions. It is difficult (and possibly grounds for libel) to quote specific material. However, our interpretation of the answers we received consistently supported our previous speculations. Although most of our respondents had great respect and appreciation for the intellectual guidance given by their mentors, most of them reported feeling an absence of personal closeness or empathy in the relationship. This is not to say that they did not rely on and trust their sponsors for professional advice in taking academic positions, or finding out about sources of grant funds, etc. They did, but the locus of control was usually in the hands of the senior person who wangled funds and positions for his protégé, and the exercise of that control normally involved no more than an impersonal perfunctory exhibition of affect on his part.

It was difficult to come to any but the most tentative conclusions about the morality or conventionality of those reported on. By and large, our respondents knew little about the personal lives of their mentors. The latter reportedly had a very strict sense of scientific ethics, but, as far as known, had relatively little concern with middle-class conventionality.

In the area of psychopathology, most of these influential men apparently had no gross symptomatology. If they did, it was not obvious to their students, and at any rate did not greatly interfere with their professional work.

The lack of ideological commitment posed a somewhat different interpretive problem. Our respondents reported general agreement with the findings of the study by Lazarsfeld and Thielens (1958) on social science faculty members that

by and large their mentors were politically liberal. However, those who were most active in power positions, as, for example, members of foundation boards, policy committees, of professional organizations, etc., were not reported to have been politically active in organizing petitions, participating in protest movements, or other activities which required a major committment of time. The few ideological activists were more renowned for their research and theoretical contributions than for their closeness to the centers of power.

All in all, these informal interviews about the behavior of power figures in the behavioral sciences suggested that our initial formulations were not completely in error. In fact, the answers were so consistently congruent that they encouraged us to look further.

In reviewing then recent psychological work dealing with political behavior, Eysenck's *The Psychology of Politics* (1954) was examined. He had proposed a two-factor theory of political behavior. One of the dimensions was political radicalism–conservatism (*R* scale). This variable appeared well established and measurable in the British populations tested, and it was in accord with similar findings in a variety of earlier research. The second dimension, "Tough–Tendermindedness" *(T)* was much more provocative since, at first glance, it seemed as though *T* should be related to the kind of interpersonal orientation in which we were interested. *R* and *T* correlated only −.12, which suggested that they might be independent of one another. However, scrutiny of the factor loadings on the items used by Eysenck (1954, Table XX, p. 129) revealed that the *T* scale items had a higher load loading on *R* than on *T*. A plot of these items (Christie, 1956a, Figure 1, p. 419) graphically indicated that *none* of Eysenck's *T* scale items was free of major contamination with political ideology. The problem with Eysenck's interpretation was that his items had been selected from scales constructed in the 1930's and 1940's and had ideological content. Thus his small samples of members of the Communist and Fascist parties were viewed as "Toughminded," but Communists were left and Fascists right on political radicalism-conservatism; Socialists and Conservatives were "Tenderminded" but left and right, respectively, on *R*. My disagreements with Eysenck have been spelled out in fuller detail elsewhere (Christie, 1955, 1956a, 1956b).

Although Eysenck's analysis had an initial plausibility, it did not jibe with a variety of material on political party membership. Almond (1954) in an interview study of Communist defectors pointed out that there were marked differences in the sorts of people who were attracted to the Communist party at different historical periods. Those from middle-class backgrounds had joined for reasons quite different from those of working-class origins. Almond also made the point that those who did not defect tended to come from a working-class background and were more pragmatic in their reasons for belonging to the party. The middle-class intellectuals who had joined for ideological reasons consistent with their political beliefs and personality structure became disillusioned more

quickly and defected when they felt their ideals were violated. This corroborated the analyses made of the backgrounds of the elite in the Nazi Party in Germany, among Communists in both Russia and China, and the Kuomintang in China (Lerner, 1951; North, 1952; Schueller, 1951). When these movements were small, highly ideological, and revolutionary, their leadership was predominantly drawn from disaffected intelligentsia of middle-class background. As these movements became successful, the earlier leaders were gradually displaced by less ideologically oriented and more organizationally minded individuals, largely from lower-status backgrounds. Although I know of no systematic survey of religious movements, a somewhat similar pattern appears more common than not. The originators are often charismatic, their successors organization men.

The point of the preceding argument is that it is a gross oversimplification to think of *the* Communist, Fascist, or for that matter, Democratic or Republican personality type. Almost every political or religious movement has its aggregate of impractical zealots and nonideological realists. The proportions of these in power positions apparently varies with the state of development of the movement.

We decided to read further. The problem of interpersonal power has engaged writers and thinkers in Western and non-Western cultures for centuries. The first interactions recorded in Genesis are between God and Adam: the first verbal interchange occurred when God warned Adam about the danger of eating of the fruit of the Tree of Knowledge in the Garden of Good and Evil. The second exchange was between Adam and Eve, the third was between Eve and the serpent, "more subtile than any beast of the field which the Lord God had made."

While it is interesting that in the Bible the first use of deception occurs before the first use of physical force (Cain's slaying of Abel), it would appear that prehistoric man first wielded power over others by physical strength. Most folk tales and mythologies, however, contain examples of both forms of control, and it is clear that tactics other than those of complete candor have long characterized man.

Our next step was to examine the writings of ancient and modern power theorists with a particular aim in mind — that of uncovering common assumptions about the nature of man and the most efficient ways to control other men. The search was both frustrating and fascinating. The frustration arose from the fact that although there seemed to be common implicit assumptions about the condition of man on the part of various power theorists, these were seldom spelled out clearly, and had to be inferred. The fascination came from the unusual sources we uncovered, particularly those from ancient non-Western civilizations. One such work was *The Book of Lord Shang,* written circa 300 B.C. in China (translated by Duyvendak, 1928). Lord Shang was extremely pragmatic in giving suggestions to rulers about the most efficient way to

administer a country. However, pragmatism was so alien to the traditional culture of China that the book was banned there for centuries.

Perhaps the most esoteric work was the *Arthaśāstra* of Kautilya (Chānakya, believed to be prime minister of Chandragupta in southern India, circa 300 B.C.), translated by Shamasastry (1909). India at that time, if Kautilya's advice was based on social reality, made Renaissance Italy appear by comparison a kindergarten playground. Kautilya provided detailed instructions for setting up systems of internal and external spies, for having spies test the loyalty of ministers by offering them religious, monetary, or sexual temptations, and for ascertaining whether ministers were susceptible to fear. He even included instructions on how the king should protect himself against being stabbed in the back while pleasurably engaged in his harem.

There is a curious footnote to the history of the *Arthaśāstra*. It was lost for 2000 years before being rediscovered early in the twentieth century and translated into English by Shamasastry. According to Brown (1953, p. 49),

> the remarkably utilitarian character of the material, caused something like an upheaval in Indian political studies. It was hailed as welcome proof of the practical turn of the Indian mind, which had been the subject of Western criticism because of its alleged preoccupation with mysticism and idealism.

Our reading of *The Book of Lord Shang,* the *Arthásāstra,* and other writings of ancient and modern power theorists left us with the conviction that, despite the differences in time and in the cultures in which the observations were made, there were two common implicit themes. One was the assumption that man is basically weak, fallible, and gullible. This unflattering view of human nature was intertwined with a second theme: if people are so weak, a rational man should take advantage of the situation to maximize his own gains. Alternatively, if others cannot be trusted because of their weaknesses, one should take steps to protect oneself from their follies.

No survey of power theorists could fail to include Machiavelli's *The Prince* and *The Discourses* (1940). I had first read Machiavelli as an undergraduate. Life during the depression in the dust bowl was quite different from the world of Florence in the early years of the sixteenth century. Most of the efforts of the people I had known at the time were directed toward physical survival in a harsh environment. Machiavelli, his advice, and the situations in which it was relevant were all not only bizarre; they were highly immoral, if not downright despicable, from the perspective of the ethical norms of the Bible Belt and Horatio Alger.

In the years intervening between my first and second reading of Machiavelli, I had had a good deal of first-hand experience with people who were professionally involved in the control of others. Their roles varied from university presidents, deans, and departmental chairman to officials in the military and civil branches of government, to foundation executives, but there were noticeable